

## Review

# The benefits (and costs) of sexual responsiveness in romantic relationships

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**Abstract**

Sex is one unique way people can show responsiveness in romantic relationships. Being and having a sexually responsive partner—who is understanding and motivated to make sexual compromises—is associated with sexual desire maintenance, sexual satisfaction, and relationship quality, especially when partners have different sexual interests or are coping with sexual issues.

But, if being responsive to a partner's sexual needs involves self-neglect, sexual responsiveness no longer has these benefits and can be costly. Future research on sexual responsiveness should involve the development of a comprehensive measure incorporating lay perceptions and considering gendered sexual expectations, and an investigation of the balance between sexual autonomy and responsiveness in relationships.

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**Introduction**

Sex is one way that partners can show responsiveness in romantic relationships. The vast majority (about 90%) of sexual experiences occur in the context of established romantic relationships [1] and most romantic relationships are sexually monogamous [2], which means that, for many people, sex is one unique way they can express love and care to a romantic partner (see [3] for a review). Also, given that desire tends to decline over time in relationships [4] and that partners often have discrepant

needs and preferences [5,6], most couples cannot rely on partners having simultaneous, spontaneous interest in sex to maintain their sexual connection. That means the maintenance of sexual desire and satisfaction over time in relationships often involves partners demonstrating some degree of responsiveness to each other's sexual needs. Nevertheless, although sexual responsiveness can help maintain satisfying romantic relationships, there are risks of harm when not paired with agency, or consideration for both partners' needs.

**What does it mean to be sexually responsive?**

Sexual responsiveness in relationships has been conceptualized as understanding, accommodating, and being willing or motivated to meet a partner's sexual desires (e.g., [7–9]). Research applying theories of communal motivation to sexuality demonstrates that people higher in *sexual communal strength*—who are motivated to be responsive to a partner's sexual needs consider the benefits to their partner when making sexual decisions [10], tend to engage in sex to foster intimacy in their relationship [8], and do so for autonomous reasons, such as inherent pleasure and meaning, rather than out of obligation [11]. Sexual responsiveness can also be thought of as a willingness to make sexual changes or compromises for a partner, such as engaging in sex more frequently than desired or accommodating a partner's sexual interests. In one study, participants indicated making sexual changes for a partner “some-what often” or “very often” on average. When people reported making sexual changes more often and feeling satisfied in doing so, both partners reported higher relationship satisfaction [7].

In qualitative research, people also indicated that sexual responsiveness involved the motivation to understand and meet each other's sexual needs. This included listening to (or sensing/knowing) and honoring each other's likes, dislikes, and boundaries. It also included paying attention to both verbal and nonverbal signals, being willing to experiment sexually, and pursuing mutual satisfaction (e.g., adjusting sexual activities to suit both partner's needs; [9]). Sexual responsiveness also involves respecting a partner's disinterest in sex at times [12], avoiding pressure, and emphasizing consent

[9]. Although most of the themes identified in participant-informed definitions of sexual responsiveness involved *accommodation*, or incorporation of a partner's sexual desires into the sexual relationship, while respecting one's own boundaries, a small number involved sexual *concession* or compliance (i.e., engaging sexually to avoid conflict or out of fear of losing their partner; [9]). Associations between sexual compliance and relationship quality show mixed results; sexual compliance has been associated with a person's own higher intimacy [13] and commitment [14], but has also been associated with lower relationship satisfaction [15]. Thus, it is important to understand when, for whom, and under which circumstances sexual responsiveness is helpful or harmful.

### The benefits of sexual responsiveness

As with responsiveness in relationships in general [16,17], being responsive and perceiving a partner as responsive in the sexual domain can support the maintenance of relationship quality (e.g., [18]). In fact, people higher in sexual communal strength report higher sexual desire and maintain higher desire over time [19,8]. They are perceived by their partner as more responsive to their needs during sex, and, in turn, both partners report higher sexual satisfaction and relationship quality [19,20]. Among people in consensually non-monogamous (CNM) relationships, perceiving a primary partner as higher in sexual communal strength is associated with greater sexual satisfaction in that relationship and in another, concurrent relationship [21]. Although perceptions of responsiveness in general are also associated with higher desire for potential and long-term partners [22,23], responsiveness in the specific domain of sexuality is associated with desire and satisfaction above and beyond general responsiveness [8,20], suggesting that sexual responsiveness plays a unique role in relationship maintenance.

Perceiving a partner as sexually responsive may be particularly important for the relationship quality of people who have unfulfilled sexual or intimacy needs or who are coping with sexual challenges, such as a clinical sexual issue. People tend to hold sexual ideals—attributes they prefer in a sexual partner—and it is common for partners to fall short of these ideals. Unmet sexual ideals are associated with lower sexual and relationship satisfaction, but people with sexually responsive partners are buffered against lower satisfaction when they have unmet sexual ideals, in part because they see their partner as more responsive and may trust them to meet their needs even if they do not possess their ideal attributes [24]. Even with couples facing clinical sexual issues such as low sexual desire or pain during sex, partners who remain motivated to be responsive to each other's sexual needs report higher well-being and satisfaction [25–28]. Similarly, among

couples who are transitioning to parenthood, a time when sexual desire and satisfaction tend to be lower (e.g., [29]), both partners can maintain higher sexual satisfaction when one partner is sexually responsive [28]. Sexual responsiveness is also particularly important for anxiously attached partners (who tend to have higher intimacy needs that they struggle to meet [30]). On days when anxiously attached people see their partner as more sexually responsive, they are buffered against the lower relationship quality they typically report [31].

As evidence that sexual responsiveness involves the ability to navigate changes and see sexual issues as opportunities for growth, people higher in sexual growth beliefs (who view a satisfying sex life as requiring hard work and effort to maintain; [32]) tend to be more sexually responsive and show responsiveness even in the face of sexual challenges [33]. In contrast, the findings for those higher in sexual destiny beliefs (who view sexual satisfaction as the result of natural compatibility evident from the start of the relationship) are mixed, with some samples reporting higher [34] and others reporting lower sexual responsiveness [33]. Importantly, among couples coping with clinically low sexual desire, when the partners of women with low desire were higher in sexual destiny beliefs, they were less sexually responsive (i.e., less motivated to meet their sexual needs) [33], possibly because they see satisfaction as the result of natural compatibility and may not believe work and effort should be required to improve one's sex life. It is also important to point out that being sexually responsive is not just about focusing on the need to have sex, but also involves understanding sexual disinterest at times. Highly sexually responsive people are more likely to reassure their partners of their love and care when rejecting their partner's sexual advances [35], and they tend to be more understanding and less resentful when their partner declines their sexual advances [36].

### When sexual responsiveness might Be costly

Being a sexually responsive partner does not mean meeting a partner's sexual needs unequivocally, but instead involves aiming to understand and be open to a partner's sexual interests, while still asserting your own needs and boundaries [37]. Sexual responsiveness that involves self-neglect (i.e., high unmitigated sexual communion) is associated with lower desire and satisfaction in community samples [20,11], greater sexual distress among women coping with clinically low levels of sexual desire [25], and poorer sexual functioning, greater anxiety, and depressive symptoms, and greater pain in clinical samples of women coping with pain during sex, as well as lower relationship satisfaction for both partners [12,28]. When sexual responsiveness is

not mitigated by one's own agency (i.e., the ability to express and assert sexual needs and interests), it is more likely to involve engaging in sex out of obligation or due to external pressure [11] and feeling disconnected and apathetic during sex [19], which explains its association with lower desire and sexual and relationship satisfaction. Sexual responsiveness may also be impacted by heterosexual norms that promote men's sexual assertiveness and women's submissiveness (e.g., [38]) and gender inequalities that limit women's sexual agency [39]. In one study of college-age women in dating relationships with men, although women who were more motivated to be responsive to their partner's sexual needs reported higher sexual desire, they were also less assertive in their sexual refusal when their partner was sexually coercive [40]. Therefore, sexual responsiveness can have personal and relational benefits but only outside of self-neglect, external pressure, or partner coercion that limits sexual assertiveness and agency. A meaningful extension in future research is to continue to test the conditions under which sexual responsiveness is costly or limits sexual agency, especially with consideration for gendered sexual norms.

### Future directions and conclusions

A key next step in this area of research is to refine the conceptual definition and assessment of sexual responsiveness that incorporates recent work on lay perceptions [9] and considers the role of heterosexual norms in how sexual responsiveness can be internalized [40]. The potential for sexual responsiveness to have costs might be heightened in casual sexual relationships in which there is less interdependence between partners than in established relationships, but no work to our knowledge has investigated sexual responsiveness outside of established romantic relationships. It is also possible that at times when partners are both higher in sexual desire (as is often the case in early dating relationships) that sexual responsiveness might be less important for sexual and relationship quality; it might be most relevant when couples have lower desire or are coping with sexual differences. Future research testing whether the associations with sexual responsiveness differ at different relationship stages or types (i.e., newer dating relationships, casual sexual relationships) could inform when the costs and benefits of sexual responsiveness might be heightened.

Given the benefits of being sexually responsive, but the risks of being overfocused on a partner's sexual needs, another key next step is to consider how to foster sexual responsiveness in relationships while keeping this balance in mind. Past work has demonstrated that is possible to shift people's own, and perceptions of their partner's, sexual responsiveness. When sexual responsiveness is enhanced, people tend to make more communal sexual decisions and maintain satisfaction

even in the face of unmet sexual ideals [10,24]. But, if there are factors like coercion or self-neglect that limit agency, a communal approach to a sexual relationship can have risks. A key challenge moving forward is considering how we can promote sexual responsiveness in relationships without promoting unmitigated responsiveness, perhaps by considering both responsiveness and assertiveness or by distinguishing between sexual responsiveness that is autonomously or intrinsically motivated versus externally pressured or obligatory [11].

Clinicians helping couples strike this balance between autonomy and responsiveness might suggest that partners honor their genuine feelings of disinterest, engage in sex when responsiveness is intrinsically motivated, and acknowledge and respond warmly to a partner's bids for sexual connection—even when rejecting their sexual advances. Systems-based approaches to couples and sex therapy have been applied to help partners regulate their emotions and sit with the uncertainty that can be involved in effectively balancing autonomy and responsiveness [41]. One part of this process relevant to sexual responsiveness is encouraging open sexual communication between partners, however, couples experiencing sexual challenges often avoid sharing their sexual preferences, and in turn, have a poorer understanding of each other's sexual needs [42]. Sexual assertiveness has been shown to buffer these barriers to sexual communication [43], and sexual discussions are a way partners can convey sexual responsiveness by showing understanding and perspective-taking. Given the proposition that high-quality listening (i.e., conveying attention and comprehension with positive regard for the speaker) can foster perceived partner responsiveness [16] and that feeling listened to creates connection [44], one way to facilitate sexual responsiveness during sexual discussions might be to promote high-quality listening in partners. In fact, high-quality listening might be particularly important during discussion of sexual topics as people tend to struggle more with sexual compared to non-sexual communication because of the greater potential for feelings of shame and embarrassment tied to their sexual identity or the vulnerability that might be required for open sexual discussions [45]. In fact, partners are more apt to respond to each other's expressed gestures of warmth (i.e., nodding synchronously, smiling at one another) when navigating sexual, compared to non-sexual, conflict discussions [45]. In relationships broadly, responsiveness is linked to higher satisfaction when autonomy needs are also met [46,47] and an important next step is to determine which dyadic processes impinge on or promote the balance of sexual autonomy and sexual responsiveness within relationships.

### Author contributions

**Amy Muise:** Conceptualization, Supervision, Writing—Original Draft Preparation, Writing—Reviewing and

Editing **Katarina Kovacevic**: Writing—Reviewing and Editing. **Ariel Shoikhedbrod**: Writing—Reviewing and Editing. **Akshita Uppot**: Writing—Reviewing and Editing.

## Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

## Data availability

No data was used for the research described in the article.

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